ART

CHURNING *the* FURNACE

The ***Shakti: Fair & Fierce*** exhibition at NGMA, New Delhi, sees women artists expressing themselves in a range of material









(Clockwise from top) Arpana Caur's 'Day and Night'; Shanthamani Muddaiah's 'Desire'; Keerti Pooja's 'Generational Echoes'; and Seema Kohli's 'Lal Dead – The Moon Stirred in Me'

Shakti: Fair & Fierce, at the National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA) in New Delhi, demands two visits. One for tasting and the second for devouring whole! With over one hundred artworks by 55 Indian women artists, thoughtfully curated by Sushma K. Bahl, with inputs from Meghna Vyas Arora of the NGMA, the show is visually arresting, heart-felt and transgressive.

'Desire', by Shanthamani Muddaiah, for instance, looks like an enormous black tongue. Thrust up at an angle, its surface covered in short charcoal sticks, it licks the whole universe with its raw energy. The charcoal echoes the raging fire that created it. We do not see the monstrous gullet from which the tongue protrudes, nor hear its roaring scream, yet we are scorched by that infinite furnace.

The white and gold mandala of Richa Navani's 'The Epic of Mahabharata Cowrie', suspended in the air, echoes another scream. Hundreds of small cowrie shells spiral in a neat and perfect circle. But one end trails on the floor. In that lone trailing strand, we see a sari unravelling. The intimations of a terrible war. And the disrobing of an ancient culture, as successive generations of the young women of today are betrayed by the society around them.

THE MUSEUM OF SACRED ART IN BELGIUM PARTNERED WITH THE NGMA TO MAKE *SHAKTI: FAIR & FIERCE* POSSIBLE

Sonal Varshneya's 'Vachik' is a panel of 25 etching prints, bristling with anecdotes. From the jaunty designs on the women's clothes to the giant potato sprouting wildly on a kitchen table, these are stories of small-town life, acutely observed. To produce multi-coloured editions requires tremendous technical skill, which makes these highly detailed scenes truly astonishing.

The same can be said, over and over again, for all the works at the show. The embroideries, for instance, are frankly superb. Jyoti Bala creates 'Chamba Rumals', a traditional art form in which fine cotton panels are stitched so that both sides are different. Shobha Broota's deceptively simple constructions out of cotton and wool yarn in contrasting colours draw the eye to return repeatedly, teasing out patterns and rhythms.